



EMPTY ORIGIN

NORA WHITCOMB



CHAPTER ONE

[LOCATION: EARTH]

[RUN: UNSET]

“Don’t follow me. Wait for the fire.”

Vharos has almost nothing left in his health bar. Neither do I. Twelve of us have spent three hours learning how to die in this room, and Liam is about to die trying to heal me.

“Nyx, you’re out of range.”

“I know. Stay there.”

Black flame spreads across the obsidian between my character and the raid. There’s a gap opening on the left, the same gap that killed me on the last pull. I keep my thumb off Blink. My damage numbers stop. For one horrible second I can see the argument we’re going to have if this costs us the record.

The flame thins.

“Now. Left. Everyone left.”

Nyx flashes through first. I turn the camera, count the bodies coming behind her, and start hitting the boss again before I’ve finished counting. Liam’s heal lands. Somebody is yelling the last percent into my ear as if the game needs encouragement.

“HE’S DOWN! HE’S FUCKING DOWN!”

The scream detonates through my headset half a second before six other voices pile on top of it, and Discord stops being a conversation and becomes weather. Somebody wants the timer checked. Somebody is already clipping it. Somebody keeps saying my handle like a chant, Nyx, Nyx, you beautiful bitch, and I'm laughing too hard to answer any of them.

On my monitor, Vharos the Undying collapses to his knees in a storm of black fire, his enormous health bar finally, finally empty. His sword hits the obsidian floor first. His body follows with enough force to shake the camera.

[VHAROS THE UNDYING: DEFEATED]

[MYTHIC CLEAR]

[NEW SERVER RECORD: 06:42]

"Six forty-two!"

"Somebody send it to Derek."

"Don't," I say, laughing into my hand. The bedroom wall is thin enough that I can hear my neighbor's television through it. "Let him find it."

A notification flashes in the corner of the screen.

Derek: fuck all of you

Too late.

There are eleven people watching my stream. Eleven. Not exactly the screaming stadium I picture whenever I tell myself NyxLive is going to take off someday, but eleven people just watched us beat Derek's group by thirty-seven seconds, so tonight those eleven beautiful bastards are enough.

pixelwitch: LMAOOOOOO

BoredAtWork88: DEREK IN SHAMBLES

ManaAddict: nyx carried

Derek: banned

I lean toward my mic. "Thank you, ManaAddict. Finally, someone recognizes talent."

"You died twice," Liam says.

"Mechanics."

"You blinked into lava."

"Advanced mechanics."

My chat fills with laughing emotes and I grin at the monitor, because this stupid, perfect little pocket of the night is why I keep doing it. I want eleven thousand someday. Enough that NyxLive stops being the thing I squeeze between classes and closing shifts and becomes the thing that pays rent, enough that I can hand in my apron at Brewed Awakening and never again ask another human being whether they want room for cream. For six hours I haven't thought about tomorrow's class or the milk crusted under the steam wand at work. Liam is still arguing with chat about my damage numbers. I turn him up.

And Nyx just killed Vharos the fucking Undying.

My stomach growls loudly enough that Liam hears it through the mic.

"What the hell was that?"

"Betrayal." I pull the headset off one ear. "I need food."

"At two thirteen in the morning?"

"Yes, Mom."

"You have food?"

I look toward the kitchen. Technically. "Fuck you."

More laughter follows me into the kitchen, headset hanging off one ear. Seven steps from my desk, eight if I avoid the floorboard that sounds like a dying goose. The refrigerator hums beneath a cabinet door that hasn't closed properly since I moved in three months ago. Inside: ranch, three eggs, pickles, one slice of cheese, and a take-out container I am unwilling to acknowledge as mine. My emergency energy drink waits behind the milk.

Mom stood in this spot on move-in day with both refrigerator doors open.

"You know you can still come home, right?"

"I know."

"You could save money."

Dad appeared behind her carrying a box marked BATHROOM that contained my gaming speakers. "Your mother means please come home before this building kills you."

Class at nine. I need to call Mom. My phone.

“Maya?”

The last thing I know about Earth is the hiss of my headset, the smell of overcooked eggs, and eleven people watching Nyx stand victorious over a dead king.

Cold touches my cheek.

I flinch away from it without opening my eyes, turning my face into something soft and damp, and another drop lands near my temple and slides into my hair. For a while I lie there trying to understand why my ceiling is leaking on me. The thought doesn’t survive long. My ceiling is six feet above my bed, for one thing. Also I’m not in my bed. I wasn’t even in bed. I was at my desk.

My eyes open.

Gray fills my vision, enormous and shifting. It isn't drywall and it isn't the weak predawn light that leaks through the bent blinds in my bedroom. It moves, clouds folding over one another across a sky so wide my brain refuses to make sense of it.

A raindrop hits me directly in the eye.

"Fuck."

I squeeze it shut, turn my head, and grass brushes my lips. Actual grass.

I go still. Rain taps against leaves somewhere nearby, thousands of soft impacts gathering into a steady whisper. Something cold has soaked through the side of my shirt. Damp earth presses against my hip and shoulder, and the air smells green and wet, rich with soil and crushed plants and something faintly sweet I can't place.

I push myself onto one elbow, and the world tilts hard enough that I stop there, breathing through a wave of nausea that brings the eggs back with unfortunate clarity. The eggs. My desk. Liam saying my name through the headset. My phone sitting just out of reach. Mom. I remember trying to get to it, and then nothing.

"What the fuck?"

My voice disappears into the rain. I sit up, and forget about the eggs.

I'm in a clearing. Tall grass bends beneath the rain in every direction, silver-green blades brushing my bare legs, tiny white flowers clustered among them with their petals folded tight against the weather. Beyond the clearing a forest rises beneath the bruised sky, and for several seconds all I can do is stare.

The trees are enormous. Their pale trunks climb straight out of the dark undergrowth, broad enough that I couldn't get both arms around one even with three people helping, smooth ivory bark darkening in the rain, the lowest branches beginning high enough to scrape the roof off my apartment building. The leaves are wrong too, long and narrow and almost blue beneath the clouds, overlapping in dense layers that turn everything past them into shadow. Rain catches along their edges before spilling toward the ground in shining streams, and mist moves slowly between the trunks.

I stare up through the pale branches until rain runs into my open mouth. I've scrolled past pictures like this and assumed somebody was lying about the filters.



CHAPTER NINE

[LOCATION: GREYWARD]

[RUN: UNSET]

I don't know where she is now," Vey says. "When I last saw her, she was leaving Rook House on foot. She was alive, and she was angry. That was four years ago."

Four years.

I press my thumb against the woman's photograph. The nail covers one of her shoulders.

"You saw her."

"Yes."

"Not someone who looked like her. Her."

"She had shorter hair by then. But yes."

The card says MERCER, ELENA RUTH. Below that is a birth date in 1993, an issue date in 2023, an expiration date in 2029. An address in Independence. I have driven through Independence. I have complained about traffic there with the air-conditioning on and a drink sweating in the cup holder.

Four years here. A card issued in 2023.

I can't make those numbers useful without knowing when she left, when she arrived, how long she stayed. My brain keeps trying anyway. I start subtracting, lose track, and start again. How old would Mom be? I haven't even got the right year to start from.

“Elena,” I say.
Vey’s eyes sharpen.
I wish I hadn’t given him that for free.
“That is the name we had.”
“Why do you have her card?”
“She left possessions in a chest. The chest remained when she went.”
“You kept them.”
“The house kept them. I brought this one from the collection.”
“Collection,” I repeat.
Ordway pushes a sack away from my elbow before I knock it over.
Vey looks at her, then at the customers passing behind us.
“Would you prefer somewhere private?”
“I’d prefer you answer.”
“Rook buys unusual objects. Some are recovered from abandoned holdings. Some are sold to us. Some are left by people who don’t return. They are inventoried. I don’t administer the collection.”
“But you use it to hire people.”
“Occasionally.”
Tolliver is looking at the card now. His mouth is set in a way I recognize from our room, just before an answer gets expensive.
“Did you know?” I ask him.
“I knew they wanted someone who could read strange writing. I hadn’t seen that.”
“Is that why you found me?”
“No.”
The answer has force behind it. Several feet away, a woman turns with a spool in her hand.
He lowers his voice. “I was coming back from a message run. You were on the slope above the creek. I didn’t go into those woods looking for you.”
“Why did you think I could read it?”
“The marks on your shirt.”
I feel the wet cotton again, the hem torn off for my foot, his coat pulled closed over it. CRIT HAPPENS. A stupid joke I bought because Liam had one in a worse color.



CHAPTER TEN

[LOCATION: ROAD TO ROOK]

[RUN: UNSET]

Everything I own fits inside a flour sack.

The keeper gives me one with a split seam and lets me use her needle while she counts yesterday's money. I mend it badly, turn the repaired side inward, and put my Earth clothes at the bottom. The shirt still smells faintly of the forest. I fold the black shorts inside it and tie the bundle with a piece of string so I won't have to see it every time I need something.

The contract and gate slip go inside a fold of the woolen garment while I pack, then against my chest when I put it on. Elena's name goes with them. The candle is too short to be much use, but I take it anyway.

Breakfast costs a bit. Six left.

"Key?" the keeper asks.

"It bolts from inside."

"Then you're done."

I wait beside the table until she looks up again. Right. No receipt. I shift the sack to my other hand.

"Thank you for witnessing."

"Read it again when you get there. Make sure their copy matches."

She goes back to her counting.

Outside, the town is only partly awake. A baker is shoveling ash into a bucket. A woman passes carrying two live hens under her arms, both straining toward the ground. I keep expecting to feel the empty room behind me. Mostly I feel the sack bumping my leg.

Ordway is at her stall before the sun reaches the roofs.

"I'm going," I say.

She looks at the sack. "So I see."

I tell her about the six days, the pay, the return cart. She asks to see the paper. I hold it while she reads so the corners don't drag through the damp.

"A piece a day," she says. "Would've offered you that for another morning."

"I know."

"No, you didn't. I hadn't offered."

I laugh, and then my throat hurts.

She takes the paper between her fingers at the departure clause. "If they argue with this, send word with a carrier. Put my stall on it. I can't fetch you, but I can get a warden to ask why."

"I don't want you owing somebody for me."

"Then pay the carrier."

She reaches under the table and brings out a small cloth bag.

"Yesterday's heel. Cheese is good. Hester sent the bread when I told her you might leave."

I accept it and feel the bread through the cloth. I had been trying to decide how to ask the price.

"Tell her thank you."

"Come tell her yourself sometime."

She takes the knot of my flour sack apart, tightens it properly, and gives it back. Then a customer arrives for lamp wicks and our goodbye has to make room for him.

At the gate, Bertran reads my departure into the book. I keep the slip; he marks it to show I have left. If I come back after the provisional term, he says, we will make a new entry. I understand the distinction well enough to nod without looking at Tolliver.

He is waiting beside a cart loaded with canvas-wrapped crates. His bow is strung. A second cart stands behind it, higher-sided, with sacks roped beneath a cover. Master Vey is arguing with a woman about whether his chest belongs on top.



CHAPTER ELEVEN

[LOCATION: ROOK]

[RUN: WARDER]

“Who was the other person?”

Vey pulls his chair nearer the table. A man behind him laughs at something, loud enough to make me hate him for half a second.

“Iven Orrel. A sluicewright in the house’s employ.”

“Did you know him?”

“Yes.”

“What happened?”

“I wasn’t below with them.”

“Then start where you were.”

He looks at the tracing beneath my hand.

“I was in the counting room. Someone came for me because there had been an accident at the south works. By the time I reached the headwall, Elena was up. Wet to the waist. She had rope burns on both hands. She kept asking them to lower the gate again.”

“The second gate?”

“I don’t know what she called them. They had stopped the inner wheel by the time I arrived.”

“Why wouldn’t they open it?”

“Because the man who worked it had just lost someone.”

I lift my hand off the paper. There is a damp print where my palm was.

Vey takes a slow breath.

"She said Iven was on a stair. There was no stair on the works plan. She wanted the wheel turned to a particular position so she could go back for him. The foreman refused. They'd had water rising in a chamber that should have been drained. His first duty was to the people he could still reach."

"What did you do?"

"I agreed with him."

The answer makes his face harder to look at. I can imagine him on the bank saying something reasonable while Elena tears skin off her hands trying to get past him.

I catch myself watching his sleeve again and turn back to the tracing.

"Did anyone look afterward?"

"They sounded the lower pool. Dragged the outlet. Sent men along both banks for three days. Nothing was recovered."

"A search for a body."

"Yes."

"She was asking for a search for a person."

"She was."

My thumb catches the edge of the table. A splinter lifts without breaking off. I press it flat again.

"How long after that did she leave?"

"Eleven days. I remember because I was still arranging wages for the search crews."

"And you decided 'argument about safety' covered this when you were hiring me."

"No. I decided you might refuse to come if I told you before you saw the writing."

For a moment I have nothing to say.

The common room carries on around us. I had been ready to drag the admission out of him. Instead he sits there waiting while I unclench my teeth.

"You don't get credit for saying that now."

"I wasn't asking for it."

"Then why say it?"

"Because Dain will tell you tomorrow."



CHAPTER TWELVE

[LOCATION: ROOK]

[RUN: WARDER]

Mara asks me to read it again.

I do.

She draws the scrap closer with one finger. Her nail has a split near the edge. I watch it catch on the paper because looking at her face feels like something I should ask permission to do.

“When did she write that?” I ask.

“The morning she signed the statement. She handed it to me afterward.”

“What did she tell you it said?”

“Nothing. I thought she had written his name.”

There are six distinct pieces of writing. Mara sees me count them.

“I wasn’t examining it very closely.”

“I’m sorry.”

She shakes her head once. “So am I.”

Vey stands by the window with his hands behind his back. For once he has nothing to contribute.

I turn the scrap without lifting it. Blank on the other side.

“It doesn’t say when the pulling stopped. Or why. I don’t know if—”

"I know what you don't know."

The words come sharply. She shuts her eyes.

"I know," she says again, quieter.

A clerk brings paper. Mara shows me how to keep the copying sheet from sliding, and the ordinary instructions make it possible to start.

I copy the records, including the crossed-out sentence and the six English words. By the time my hand cramps, I am finished.

At the door she says, "He had two sons."

I turn back.

"Iven. One was small enough that we had to explain more than once."

"I'll be careful what I say."

"Yes," she says. "Please."



My room is above the west kitchen. It has a narrow bed, a peg, and a shutter opening onto a roof where someone has planted herbs in broken pots. The door bolts. I test it twice, then put my copies beneath the folded Earth shirt in my sack.

Supper is downstairs with people who have opinions about flour deliveries. Nobody asks whether Iven is alive. Nobody knows that I have spent half the afternoon considering a length of rope with a person at the other end.

Tolliver is at the far end of the table. He moves a jug so I can set my bowl down, but doesn't turn the empty place beside him into an invitation I have to refuse. I sit there because I want to.

"Paid?" I ask.

He taps his purse. "Two pieces. Sella too."

"Are you going back?"

"Eventually. Dain wants someone to walk the lower channel with him the day after tomorrow. Tracks, bank damage, animal holes. I've taken two days, paid by the day. After that I haven't decided."

"You don't have to stay because I'm here."

"I haven't asked you to pay me." He tears his bread too hard; a piece drops onto the floor. He bends to retrieve it.

I turn the bone over with my spoon, looking for the meat beneath it.

"I don't know what I want you to do."

Sella lays her hand palm-up on the blanket.
I take it and keep talking.



CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

[LOCATION: EAST RELIEF WORKS]

[RUN: WARDER]

The East Relief Works has a front door, which is disappointing. I was promised a dungeon.

The door is iron-banded oak, swollen in its frame and hanging low enough that one corner has carved a crescent through the stone threshold. Somebody painted a red hand across it years ago.

The hand has six fingers.

“That seems encouraging.”

Harra pushes once on the door. It does not move. Sella touches the faded paint with one fingertip.

“Worker mark?”

“Warning.”

“What does six fingers warn about?”

Harra considers the hand. “Usually that whoever painted it was frightened.”

“Specific.”

“More specific than no warning.”

Tolliver crouches beneath the overhang and studies the mud. The last rain has softened everything enough to hold tracks: deer, something broad-footed, our own boots from the slope. Nothing human and recent.

"No one came through since the rain."

One retreat condition cleared.

Harra takes a pry bar from his pack while I stand nearby with the walking stick the mender inflicted on me. My shield is back at Rook because medical authority has won its argument with dignity.

She works the bar toward the latch side. I look at the door again.

"Not there."

Harra pauses.

"The top hinge block is cracked. Force the latch and the door twists into it."

She studies the stone, then shifts the bar to the low corner. Tolliver puts his shoulder where she points. Sella joins him.

Wood groans. The door opens an inch.

Something knocks from inside.

Everybody stops.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

Not close. Not far either. Somewhere under us.

Harra glances back. "Still want your dungeon?"

"I would like to revise my complaint."



Inside, the air tastes of wet stone and old iron.

The first room is almost ordinary: benches, hooks, three cracked helmets, a drainage groove furred white with mineral crust. Then I notice the skeleton under a collapsed shelf.

The bones are brown with age. Anything useful was taken long ago, though a ring of green corrosion still stains one wrist. Sella stops beside it. Harra removes her cap. Tolliver does the same, and I copy them half a second late.

Nobody prays. I do not know the right prayer anyway.

We step around the bones and go on.

The next doorway opens onto a maintenance corridor ribbed in black iron. The floor is built from square stone plates, each with a metal pin at one corner.

Harra crouches.

"Isolation floor."

"So the holes really are doors," Sella says.

"When pressure failed, selected plates dropped into the trench. Kept workers from crossing into a rupture zone."

“Stop.”

He stops.

A pale hand slides into the seam.

I can feel the argument in the floor: his weight, the old mechanism, something below pushing up where the stone wants to go down. Sella mutters something behind me as another knock answers under the plate behind Tolliver.

“Back,” I say.

He shifts onto his rear foot. The plate steadies.

“Again.”

Another inch. The hand slaps stone.

They are building a rhythm.

“Stepguard,” I say, mostly to remind myself what I have.

I have no shield, but Sella taught me the pattern as a line through the body before she ever taught me to hide behind wood. I move onto the sound plate behind him.

She catches the back of my coat.

“Ankle.”

“Straight line.”

Her hand opens.

I commit.

Reserve pulls.

5 / 6 → 3 / 6

The pattern catches around my stance. My back boot stays on the chalked sound stone while my forward foot takes the edge of Tolliver’s shifting plate. Pressure comes up through that step hard enough to buckle an ordinary transfer, but the grounded foot gives Stepguard somewhere real to send it. My facing holds.

I grab the back of Tolliver’s belt.

“Do not help me.”

“I wasn’t.”

Good.

“Move when I say.”

Another knock. The plate drops.

“Now.”

He steps backward past me. I let the pattern go and follow him onto sound stone.



The stone lands.

The arm sweeps.

I plant my forearms against the back of it at the stop and Brace.

3 / 6 → 2 / 6

Pressure comes through iron, shoulders, spine, boots. The arm is dead-still under the pattern, but the mechanism behind it is not. I can feel gears trying to complete something they began twelve years ago.

“Sella.”

She runs low behind the sweep line.

A pale hand appears at the floor seam behind her.

Tolliver says, “Left.”

He fires once. The arrow pins the hand against the seam. The knocker makes a high, thin scream that brings answering knocks from beneath the whole room.

Sella reaches the far pier and yanks the lever.

Nothing.

Again.

Nothing.

“Safety catch!” Harra shouts. “Under the handle!”

Sella drops to one knee.

The arm surges against my Brace. The pattern bites down so hard my teeth click together.

“Now,” I say, and keep the word flat enough to be useful.

Sella finds the catch and throws the lever.

The pressure vanishes so fast the iron bar becomes ordinary weight against my arms. Brace releases by itself and I rock backward.

Tolliver catches my upper arm.

“Sound?”

I set both feet. “Yes.”

His hand is gone immediately.

Across the room, Sella comes around the pier, crosses after Harra clears the mechanism, and kisses me hard enough to steal the next breath.

“Good call.”

Then she turns to Harra. “Take the damned shoe.”

“Does it have eyes?”

“I am choosing optimism.”

The borer rises.

It is worse in air: long plates of pale armor, a mouth at the front opening in concentric bone.

No eyes.

Tolliver lowers the bow. “Optimism revised.”

Sella draws her knife.

I stare at it. “And your plan?”

“Emotional support.”

Fair.

The borer slams the near wall.

The ceiling track jumps. Harra nearly loses her grip.

I set both forearms against the low diagonal stay beside the capstan and Brace before I have finished deciding to do it.

2 / 6 → 1 / 6

The track steadies.

Pressure comes through iron and bone into the stone beneath my boots. Harra catches the upper bar and hauls herself upright.

Another impact.

I can hold.

That is the problem.

The track is stable because the force is going somewhere else, and the bracket above me is bending farther with every hit. I can keep the line straight until the bracket tears itself out of the wall.

The first ash frame flashes through my head, cut in half because holding harder felt safer than releasing.

“Harra.”

“I need ten breaths.”

“No.”

She looks at me.

The bracket groans.

“Five.”

The borer circles for another strike.

I release Brace.

The track drops four inches.

Harra swears, but the bent bracket gives instead of snapping. The changed angle lifts the trolley wheel over the damaged joint.

He lunges one step.
His rear boot clears the marked segment.
“Now.”
Harra slams the release lever.
The sacrificial pin shears.
The far third of the rescue board drops out of alignment just as
the boundary reaches it.
The edge cuts through the falling section.
The remaining frame jerks toward us.
Iven falls forward.
The belt snaps tight.
Tolliver hauls.
Sella pulls tether.
The near sleeve is still hard against its stop, and the frame begins
to wrench sideways.
I set both forearms against the near anchor shoe and Brace.

6 / 7 → 5 / 7

I am holding the anchor shoe, not the whole frame.
One breath of load so Harra can open the near release.
“Near.”
She slams it.
The captured sleeve opens.
The frame shifts.
The boundary drops behind Iven’s hips.
Tolliver hauls again.
Iven slides across the near board.
Hand.
Elbow.
Shoulder.
Almost through.
The old mechanism below slams.
The anchor bucks beneath my Brace.
Pain flashes through my ankle.
Sharp.
I can hold another breath.
That is exactly why I do not.
I release.

I rest my head against his shoulder for exactly one breath.
Then Sella is beside us, exhausted and bright-eyed and sad around
the edges.
She touches my boot.
“Alive?”
“Unfortunately.”
“Good.”
Tolliver lowers me onto the treatment bench.
Sella kisses my forehead and turns back to Iven.
Professional first.
Always.



The System arrives while Iven is throwing up.
Perfect.
I am sitting with my ankle elevated and holding a cup the mender
will not let me drink from yet when the measure opens.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 5]
[PROGRESS: 26 / 26]

I blink.
I had not checked the target since level five.
The text folds.

[WARDER ADVANCEMENT]
[LEVEL 6]
[RESERVE CAPACITY: 8]
[CURRENT RESERVE: 5 / 8]

More room.
Same ankle.
Good.
Then another line appears.

[TECHNIQUE RECOGNITION UPDATED]
[RELEASE UNDER LOAD → CONTROLLED RELEASE]

I stare at it.
The phrase itself is plain. What catches me is knowing exactly
which moment the System means.



CHAPTER THIRTY

[LOCATION: ROOK]

[RUN: WARDER]

Sella's wagon is late. Seven minutes. I know because I ask three different people what time it is, and the third looks at me as though I am trying to intimidate the sun into moving faster. I cannot defend myself. My ankle is wrapped again. The mender has upgraded me from *do not be stupid* to *do not stand unless the building is on fire*, which she insists is an important distinction in medicine. Iven is inside with Teren and Lio.

Pell is in the counting room with Rusk and Vey arguing over drainage rights, salvage holds, and which pieces of our ruined rescue frame count as evidence. Harra is asleep at a worktable with her cheek on a coil of rope. Tolliver is somewhere I cannot see him. Good. Sella's pack is beside the west wall. Bad.

She has changed out of the clothes she wore into the lower works. Clean shirt. Dark trousers. Soft leather coat. Bow across her back. The knife at her thigh is the same one she wore the first night we slept together. I stare long enough that she catches me.

"Really?"

"I was looking at the sheath."

"Liar."

"Tactically."

“With terrible timing.”

That hurts because it is funny. For the last two weeks she has touched me whenever she wanted: hip, shoulder, back of my neck, fingers under a table, mouth against mine in hallways. Small things that became ours by repetition. Now there is a foot of air between us. I feel every inch.

“Walk with me,” she says.

From across the room, the mender says, “No.” Sella turns. “Outside.”

“No.”

“Five steps.”

“No.”

“Three.”

The mender points at the bench. “You can sit outside with her if Tolliver carries the bench.” I close my eyes. Sella laughs. The mender does not.

“This is why healers drink,” I say.

“This is why healers poison patients.”

Tolliver appears in the doorway at exactly the wrong moment. Of course he does. He looks at the bench. Then at the mender.

“No.”

Good man. The mender raises one eyebrow.

“I’ll carry Maya,” he says. “The bench is stupid.”

“Thank you.”

She points at me. “You are the stupid part.” She has a point. Tolliver does not move until I nod. That still catches under my ribs in a way I have stopped pretending is accidental. He lifts me. Sella takes my pack because my official role has become decorative object. Outside, the afternoon is thin and bright after the rain. Rook smells like wet stone, horse sweat, boiled grain, and the sharp oil Harra uses on metal. The wagon is still not here. Seven minutes becomes nine.

Sella leads us to the low wall beside the east herb beds. Tolliver lowers me onto it, careful with the bad foot. Sella puts my pack beneath my heel. He straightens.

“Do you need anything?”

“No.”

His eyes move to Sella.

“I need ten minutes,” she says.



CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

[LOCATION: ROOK]

[RUN: WARDER]

The first thing I do after sleeping with Tolliver is argue about payroll. This is not how romance novels work. Nobody wakes after life-altering sex to find a factor, a keeper, a landholder, and one terrifyingly awake clerk downstairs with thirteen days of retained labor arranged in four columns. Yet here we are. Tolliver sits beside me at the long table with damp hair and the offensive appearance of a man who slept normally. I know what that mouth did last night. He looks like he ate breakfast.

Pell pushes the first sheet toward me.

“You said you wanted every day separated.”

“I did.”

“You refused a summary.”

“I did.”

“And you made Mara reconstruct which days you were medically restricted, which days you were consulted anyway, and when the original agreement should have ended.”

“Yes.”

Pell leans back.

“You are exhausting.”

“Pay me.”

Mara coughs into one hand. Suspiciously close to laughter. Vey does not bother hiding his. Tolliver keeps his eyes on the sheet. Smart man. Mara has separated everything: planning under restriction, equipment review, far-side coordination, rescue work, statements, measurements, copies. Two entries read REST RESTRICTION, RETAINED FOR CONSULTATION, which feels unfair until I remember making Harra carry the spring shoe into the kitchen so I could criticize it with my foot on a stool. The expedition days and the earlier paid day are marked separately so nobody counts them twice.

This sheet begins with the first unpaid recovery morning and ends yesterday. Thirteen days. Eight bits each. One hundred and four bits. Thirteen pieces. I read the total three times because another world has not cured me of expecting paperwork to bite.

“Both rest entries count?”

Pell looks almost offended.

“You remained under my instruction and unavailable for other work because of an injury sustained here. You were also consulted.”

“That is nearly reasonable.”

“Do not spread it around.”

A small sealed purse lands in front of me with the soft, dense sound of money that belongs to me. I do not touch it yet.

“Property damage?”

“None charged.”

“Treatment?”

“Covered.”

“Room?”

“Through today under the unused return-passage term.”

“Food?”

“Covered.”

“Return cart?”

Pell looks at me.

“To where?”

Greyward, technically. The original agreement assumed I would go back there after the reading work. Then I stayed. Then a trapped man and a boundary capable of cutting people in half rearranged the calendar.

"What do I call you?" he asks.

"Warder Supreme."

"No."

"Your devastatingly competent employer."

"You are not employing me."

"Good catch."

His thumb moves across my knuckles.

"Maya works."

I lean into his shoulder for maybe ten seconds. Then sit up. One more thing. I open my measure. The familiar awareness settles over me.

[MAYA SZCZEPANIAK, LV. 6]

[RUN: WARDER]

Eight reserve, full after days without spending. Brace. Stepguard. Controlled Release in the strange category where the System has named something I learned without turning it into a button. Origin still blank. It bothers me less. Once, that empty place looked like proof that I belonged nowhere. Now there is a key in my pocket. A room behind me that I paid for. A shield I bought. A chest full of things I chose to keep. A woman I love somewhere east under the same sky.

A man holding my hand because I put mine there. People downstairs who will notice if I miss breakfast.

Blank does not mean empty.

I let the measure close. Then I sign the ridge-road offer. MAYA SZCZEPANIAK. My handwriting is still ugly. Tolliver watches the ink dry.

"Six days," he says.

"Four. Two days on the cart. I want to reach Greyward before the caravan leaves and see Ordway."

His eyebrows lift.

"You planned that."

"I occasionally plan ahead."

He groans. Below us, Harra shouts that if we are really taking the ridge job, she wants two pack frames, a proper rope inventory, and written authority to refuse any idiot who tries to make her carry decorative iron. I lean over the wall.

“Are you coming?”

She looks up.

“You paying?”

“Yes.”

“Then probably.”

“Romantic.”

“Fuck off.”

Tolliver laughs. I look east. Somewhere beyond the road, Sella is moving toward the life she chose. Somewhere beyond Greyward, Elena may still be alive. Somewhere under a ridge, another old station is waiting. None of those things are mine yet. That is fine. I fold the contract and tuck it into my notebook. Four days from now, I leave Rook. Not because somebody bought my service before I understood the terms. Not because a man found me in the rain.

Not even because I am chasing a door back to Missouri. I am leaving because there is work I want, a road I have not seen, and people I have chosen to walk it with. For the first time since I woke under the trees, forward feels like a direction instead of a threat. I stand with my shield in one hand. Tolliver’s hand stays in the other for exactly three steps, until Harra yells at us to stop being useless and help with the inventory.

Home, apparently, has chores.